Website migration checklist

Move a site without losing rankings: tasks for before the move, launch day and the 8–12 weeks after, plus a 301 redirect map and a weekly tracker.

How to use this checklist

1. **Describe the migration** on the card below. The type of move decides which items apply to you.
2. **Assign owners and due dates** to every task. Tasks without an owner are the ones that get skipped.
3. **Collect URLs and a baseline** from Search Console and GA4 before you change anything. Note the export date.
4. **Fill in the redirect map** (part D): one old URL = one new URL, a 301 code and a priority.
5. **On launch day**, work through part B in order and record each test result.
6. **Once a week for 8–12 weeks**, update the tracker (part E). Add every new 404 to the map.

Migration card

Type of migration	☐ new domain ☐ new subdomain ☐ new URLs / CMS ☐ HTTP → HTTPS ☐ redesign or new hosting		
Old domain		**New domain**	
Staging URL		**Launch date and time**	
SEO owner		**Developer**	
Content owner		**Data export date**	

The Search Console Change of Address tool applies only to moves to a different domain or subdomain. For HTTP → HTTPS, www ↔ non-www and path changes on the same domain, redirects and a new sitemap are enough.

A. Before the move

	Task	Owner	Due
☐	Complete list of old URLs: sitemaps, server logs, analytics, CMS, Search Console Links report, full site crawl		
☐	Images, PDFs, JavaScript and CSS files added to the list		
☐	Search Console export (Performance): pages and queries with the most clicks		
☐	GA4 baseline: organic traffic and conversions (enter in part E)		
☐	List of 20–50 priority URLs to test on launch day		
☐	List of sites linking to old URLs		
☐	One-to-one 301 redirect map (part D), no redirects to the home page		
☐	Content with no equivalent set to return 404 or 410		
☐	Staging protected by password or noindex; note of what to remove at launch		
☐	Self-referencing canonical tags on new URLs		
☐	hreflang points to the new URLs of each language version		
☐	Structured data, title tags and meta descriptions carried over		
☐	GA4 and Google Tag Manager set up, key events tested on staging		
☐	New XML sitemap with final destination URLs only		

	Task	Owner	Due
☐	Old and new sites verified in Search Console (www and non-www), disavow file uploaded		
☐	Core Web Vitals and forms of the new version checked on staging		

B. Launch day (in this order)

	Task	Owner	Time
☐	Redirects from the map deployed before the old version stops responding		
☐	Staging blocks removed: noindex, password, unneeded Disallow rules		
☐	robots.txt on the new site blocks only what should stay hidden		
☐	Canonical tags point to the new URLs (not staging, not the old domain)		
☐	Priority URLs tested: status code, redirect target, title, content, forms (e.g. URL Inspection tool)		
☐	New sitemap submitted in Search Console		
☐	Change of Address tool submitted after redirects are live (new domain or subdomain only, from an account that owns both properties)		
☐	GA4 collecting page views, key events (forms, calls) recorded		

C. After the move (8–12 weeks)

	When	Task	Owner
☐	Week 1	Daily review of 404s and the Pages report, missing URLs added to the map	
☐	Weeks 1–2	Redirect chains collapsed to a single hop	
☐	Weeks 1–2	Internal links point to final URLs, not redirects	
☐	Weeks 2–4	Most valuable backlinks updated by the linking sites	
☐	Weeks 1–4	New URL in Google Business Profile, social profiles and ad campaigns	
☐	Every week	Clicks, impressions and priority query positions compared with the baseline (part E)	
☐	1 year min.	Redirects and old domain registration kept (Google recommends at least a year)	

D. Redirect map

Rules

- **One hop:** each old URL goes straight to its final destination, with no chains.
- **301 or 308** (permanent), not 302 or 307. Server-side redirects, not JavaScript.
- **Closest match** in content, not the home page. No equivalent = 404 or 410.
- **One URL format:** HTTPS, trailing slash or not, lowercase, www or non-www.

#	Old URL	New URL	Code	Priority	Test (date, result)
e.g.	*/services/web-design.html*	*/web-design/*	*301*	*High*	*01/12 · OK*
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					
14					
15					
16					
17					
18					
19					
20					

Priority: high = URL with Google traffic or backlinks; medium = URL in the site structure; low = everything else. For a larger site, keep the map in a spreadsheet with the same columns.

E. Weekly tracker

Week	Date	Google clicks	Impressions	404 errors	Indexed from new sitemap	Notes
Baseline						
Week 1						
Week 2						
Week 3						
Week 4						
Week 5						
Week 6						
Week 7						
Week 8						
Week 9						
Week 10						
Week 11						
Week 12						

Ranking movement in the first weeks is normal: according to Google, a medium-sized site can take a few weeks or more before the new URLs replace the old ones. Watch for a drop that sticks or a growing number of 404s.

F. Post-migration issue log

Date	Issue (URL, symptom)	Cause	Fix	Owner	Done
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐

www.ai-seo-company.pl/en/tools/website-migration-checklist

Sources: Google Search Central "How to move a site", Search Console Help "Change of Address tool" (accessed November 11, 2026)

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